
User Interface Design Document

for

Plasma: The Social Intelligence Layer for Steam

Version 1.0 approved

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Revision History

Name	Date	Reason For Changes	Version

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose

This User Interface Design Document (UIDD) provides a comprehensive guide to the visual and interactive architecture of **Plasma: The Social Intelligence Layer for PC Gaming**. Its purpose is to bridge the gap between the functional requirements outlined in the SRS and the final frontend implementation. This document will serve as the primary reference for frontend developers, UI/UX designers, and quality assurance testers to ensure a cohesive, accessible, and highly engaging user experience across the entire platform.

1.2 Document Conventions

This document strictly follows standardized typographical conventions to ensure clarity across all engineering and design teams:

- **Bold Text:** Aside from headings/sub-headings, used to indicate core platform subsystems and major features (e.g., **The Pulse**, **The Rally**). These are defined in Appendix A.
- **Italic Text:** Used to define specific user states, personas, or intent modes (e.g., *Comp Mode*, *Chill Mode*).

1.3 Scope of the User Interface

The scope of this document encompasses the entire frontend presentation layer of the Plasma web application. This includes, but is not limited to:

- **Responsive Layouts:** The structural grids and breakpoints required to translate the platform seamlessly from 4K desktop monitors down to mobile Progressive Web App (PWA) viewports.
- **Core Subsystems:** The visual flow and interactive states for the four main pillars of the platform: **The Pulse** (timeline feed), **The Rally** (event scheduling calendar), **The Omni-Library** (game database search and shelving), and **The Prestige** (achievement trophy cases).
- **Global Design System:** The standardized UI components (buttons, modals, navigation bars), typography hierarchy, and color palettes that form the visual identity of the application.

1.4 Target Audience and Personas

The interface is specifically designed to minimize cognitive load for our four core gamer personas, who frequently experience “launcher fatigue” and information overload:

- **The Shotcallers (Squad Leaders):** Require high-visibility call-to-action buttons (e.g., “RSVP”, “Create Event”) and easily scannable calendar interfaces within **The Rally** to quickly coordinate group sessions and see who is online at a glance.

- **The Completionists (Achievement Hunters):** Require high-density data visualization within **The Prestige** to clearly showcase rarity percentages, earned badges, and their accumulated “Plasma XP” on competitive leaderboards.
- **The Variety Gamers (The Socialites):** Require intuitive, visual-heavy feeds in **The Pulse** to quickly see what games are trending in their friend group, along with easy-to-access toggles to signal a casual *Chill Mode*.
- **The Pro-Am Aspirants (Competitive Players):** Require prominent, color-coded visual indicators for *Comp Mode* and robust UI filtering tools to quickly find reliable teammates while hiding casual session invites.

1.5 Core Design Principles

The visual identity of Plasma is rooted in the following design philosophies:

- **Gaming Aesthetic (Dark Mode Default):** To reduce eye strain during late-night gaming sessions and match the aesthetic of modern PC ecosystems, the application will use a high-contrast “Dark Mode” as its default and primary theme.
- **Glassmorphism:** To create a sense of depth without relying on heavy, solid blocks of color, the UI will utilize translucent, frosted-glass panelling for modals, sidebars, and dropdowns. This keeps the interface feeling lightweight and cloud-based.
- **Data-Driven Storytelling:** Raw data (like an API payload from Steam) must be transformed into visual “Moments.” The UI will prioritize rich media (game cover art, user avatars, achievement icons) over raw text whenever possible.
- **Contextual Clarity:** The interface will rely on universally recognized gaming iconography (e.g., controller icons, trophy symbols, standard “Play” buttons) to reduce the learning curve and keep navigation intuitive.
- **Standard Layout Constraints:** Every screen will feature a persistent left-hand navigation menu (on desktop) or a bottom navigation bar (on mobile) containing quick links to the four core subsystems: **The Pulse**, **The Rally**, **The Omni-Library**, and **The Prestige**.
- **Error Handling:** The UI will utilize standard, non-intrusive toast notifications for standard errors (e.g., “Failed to fetch live status” or “Event time conflicts with existing Rally”), maintaining standard error message display guidelines.

2. Graphical User Interfaces (GUIs)

2.1 Marketing Landing Page

- **Purpose:** The unauthenticated public-facing homepage designed to explain the platform's value proposition and drive user registrations.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - **Hero Section:** Features the main value proposition, “Know What Your Squad Is Playing. Always.”, and a prominent “Get Started” call-to-action button.
 - **Feature Highlights:** Distinct visual sections explaining the core pillars: **The Pulse**, **The Rally**, **The Omni Library**, **The Prestige**, and Intent Modes (“Signal Your Vibe”).
 - **Footer CTA:** A final prompt to “Join Plasma—It's free” with a concluding “Get Started” button.
- **Objectives Achieved:** User acquisition and onboarding education.
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Make the Interface Consistent:** Uses the same dark mode aesthetic and typography as the main application to build immediate brand familiarity.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the root URL. Clicking any “Get Started” button routes the user to GUI 1.3 (Sign Up Screen).

2.2 Login Screen

- **Purpose:** The authentication portal for returning users to access their Plasma dashboard.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - **Manual Login Form:** Input fields for “Username” and “Password”, followed by a primary “Log In” button.
 - **SSO Integration:** A prominent “Sign in with Steam” button separated by an “OR” divider.
 - **Footer Links:** A link routing to “Don't have an Account? Sign Up” and a disclaimer for the Terms of Service and Privacy Policy.
- **Objectives Achieved:** BR-1 (Account Verification). Gating the platform to verified users.
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - *Reduce User's Memory Load:* By offering the OpenID “Sign in with Steam” flow, users are not forced to remember legacy credentials if they prefer SSO.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the Landing Page or a direct URL. Connects to Registration Screen via “Sign Up” link. Upon successful authentication, routes the user to **The Pulse**.

2.3 Registration Screen

- **Purpose:** The account creation portal for new users to register and link their gaming identities.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - **Registration Form:** Input fields for “Username”, “Email Address”, “Password”, “Confirm Password”, and “Date of Birth”.
 - **Primary CTA:** A “Create Account” button to submit the form.
 - **Footer Links:** A link routing to “Already have an account? Sign In” and the Terms/Privacy Policy agreement text.
- **Objectives Achieved:** Secure user onboarding and initial profile generation.
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - *Place Users in Control:* Providing a “Confirm Password” field helps users catch typing errors before submitting, reducing frustration.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the “Get Started” buttons on the Landing Page and “Sign Up” links from Login Screen. Connects to the Steam OpenID linking flow upon successful account creation, then routes back to Login Screen.

2.4 Global Navigation & Social Signalling

- **Purpose:** The persistent framework that wraps all major screens, allowing for quick navigation and social status updates.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - Top global search bar (“Search players, games...”).
 - Left-hand vertical navigation menu linking to **Pulse**, **Rally**, **Omni Library**, and **Prestige**.
 - “Squad Online” sidebar showing friends' avatars, current game status (e.g., “Playing Valorant”, “In-Queue”), and colored Intent borders.
 - Global Intent Mode toggler (*COMP*, *CHILL*, *OFFLINE*) located prominently to easily signal intent to other users and filter content.
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-1 (Fetch user’s Friend list), REQ-12 (Toggle social intent state), REQ-13 (Visually distinguish active intent), REQ-14 (Provide filtering mechanism based on intent mode).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Make the Interface Consistent:** The navigation and online squad list remain anchored regardless of what subsystem the user is viewing, providing a stable spatial context.
 - **Place Users in Control:** Users can seamlessly toggle between intent modes to filter content and signal intent to other users.
- **Navigation:** User can navigate to **Pulse**, **Rally**, **Omni Library**, **Prestige** and “Account”.

2.5 The Pulse (Main Dashboard)

- **Purpose:** The primary unified social feed displaying live game statuses, user-generated moments, and deep links to launch games.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - “Share a moment” text/multimedia input box at the top of the feed.
 - Feed filters: “All”, “Friends Activity”, “My Posts”.
 - Rich-media feed cards displaying automated status updates (e.g., “Sarah started playing Helldivers 2”) and manual user uploads (e.g., Ranked recap screenshots with Plasma XP highlights).
 - Right sidebar widgets: “Trending in Squad” (showing games with active player counts) and a summarized “Upcoming Rallies” list with quick “Join” buttons.
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-1 (Fetch live status), REQ-2 (Publish multimedia moments), REQ-3 (Join Game button).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Reduce User's Memory Load:** Visual avatars and high-quality game box art immediately identify who is playing what, eliminating the need to read dense text logs.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the left-hand navigation menu.

2.6 The Rally (Event Calendar & List)

- **Purpose:** A centralized hub to view upcoming multiplayer sessions, filtered by Intent Mode, with timezone-aware scheduling.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - “Calendar” and “List” view toggle buttons.
 - “Create Rally” primary call-to-action button.
 - Event cards displaying: Game title, Intent Tag (*COMP/CHILL*), Localized Time (e.g., “11:00 PM”), Slot availability indicator (e.g., “3/5”), and an “RSVP” button.
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-4 (Dynamically calculate timezones), REQ-5 (RSVP with predefined roles), REQ-14 (Filter events by Intent Mode).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Place Users in Control:** Users can seamlessly toggle between a high-level calendar overview and a detailed daily list based on their planning preference.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the left-hand navigation menu. Clicking an event card opens “Rally Event Details Modal”. Clicking “Create Rally” opens the create Rally Modal.

2.7 Rally Event Details Modal

- **Purpose:** A detailed view for a specific event where organizers manage rosters and attendees claim specific roles.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - Large, immersive game banner art at the top.

- Event Objective text block (e.g., “Ranked grind... Diamond push tonight”).
- “Role Roster” selector with specific class capacities (e.g., DPS 2/3, Sentinel 1/2).
- “Attendees” list showing confirmed users and their selected roles alongside readiness indicators (“READY”, “IN-GAME”).
- Integrated live chat box for pre-game communication.
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-4 (Dynamically calculate timezones), REQ-5 (RSVP with predefined roles).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Reduce User's Memory Load:** Explicit capacity trackers (2/3) instantly communicate what the team needs without requiring users to manually count the roster or ask in a separate chat.

2.8 The Omni-Library (Virtual Shelf)

- **Purpose:** The main hub for users to view, search, and filter their entire collection of synced Steam and manually added non-Steam games.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - “Search any game...” dedicated library search bar.
 - Horizontal category filter tabs: “All”, “Currently Playing”, “Steam”, “Non-Steam”.
 - Summary text indicating total library count and breakdown (e.g., “47 Games | 12 Steam | 8 Non-Steam”).
 - Visual grid of game cover art displaying the user's titles.
 - “Add Non-Steam Game” placeholder card/button within the grid.
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-7 (Integrate with IGDB to retrieve metadata)
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Make the Interface Consistent:** Mimics the visual grid layout of modern desktop libraries (like Steam or Epic) to ensure instant user familiarity and comfort.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the left-hand navigation menu. Clicking a game cover opens “Game Detail Modal”. Clicking “Add Non-Steam Game” opens the IGDB search modal.

2.9 Omni-Library Game Detail Modal

- **Purpose:** A focused overlay displaying rich metadata for a specific selected game, allowing the user to manage their active status and library settings.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - Large game cover art alongside developer/publisher info and release year (e.g., “Riot Games 2009”).
 - Categorical metadata tags (e.g., MOBA, PC, STRATEGY, FREE TO PLAY).
 - Short game description/synopsis.
 - “Set Playing” toggle switch, accompanied by the subtext: “You're broadcasting this to your Pulse”.
 - “Friends Playing” list showing avatars of peers who also own/play the game.
 - Action links: “View on IGDB”, “View Achievements”, and a destructive “Remove from Library” button.

- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-7 (Integrate with IGDB API to display metadata), REQ-8 (Toggle active “Playing” status for manual games).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Place Users in Control:** Gives Ecosystem Agnostics the power to manually broadcast their gaming activity to **The Pulse**, and provides a clear, immediate exit path to remove a game if added by mistake.
- **Navigation:** Initiated by clicking any game card in **Omni Library**. Operates as an overlay; clicking the 'X' or outside the modal returns the user to the Virtual Shelf.

2.10 The Prestige (Leaderboard)

- **Purpose:** A public-facing profile highlighting the user's gamified achievements, XP, and network ranking.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - Profile header showing total Plasma XP, Global Rank, and joined date.
 - “Friends Leaderboard” widget comparing XP among peers.
 - “Hall of Fame” customizable grid displaying up to 5 pinned, rare achievements.
 - Detailed trophy list displaying the achievement name, Plasma XP value, and global unlock percentage (e.g., “0.1%”).
- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-9 (Assign Plasma XP), REQ-10 (Pin Hall of Fame achievements), REQ-11 (Manually claim achievements).
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Place Users in Control:** Providing an “Edit Hall of Fame” button allows completionists to curate their digital identity and showcase the trophies they are most proud of.
- **Navigation:** Initiated from the left-hand navigation menu. Clicking “Add Achievement” opens the manual achievement adding dialog.

2.11 User Profile Dashboard

- **Purpose:** A personalized, public-facing hub displaying a user's unified gaming identity, curated achievements, and personal activity timeline.
- **Key UI Elements:**
 - **Profile Header:** Displays the user's avatar, display name, active Intent Mode badge, and join date.
 - **Quick Stats Row:** High-level metrics blocks displaying total Plasma XP, total Achievements, Rallies joined, and total games in Library.
 - **Edit Actions:** A primary “Edit Profile” button.
 - **Hall of Fame:** A horizontal array of up to 5 pinned, circular achievement badges displaying their respective Plasma XP values, alongside an “Edit Hall of Fame” link.
 - **Content Tabs:** Navigation tabs to filter the user's specific content: **Pulse**, **Omni Library**, **Prestige**, and **Rallies**.
 - **Personal Activity Feed:** A chronological timeline of the user's specific activity. Includes rich-media posts, automated system alerts for launching games, and automated achievement unlock notifications.

- **Objectives Achieved:** REQ-10 (Pin Hall of Fame achievements) and establishing the unified cross-platform gamer profile.
- **Mandel's Golden Rules Applied:**
 - **Place Users in Control:** Prominent “Edit Profile” and “Edit Hall of Fame” buttons give the user complete agency over how their digital identity is presented to their peers.
 - **Make the Interface Consistent:** The personal activity feed utilizes the exact same card structures and interaction models (Like/Comment/Share) as the global “Pulse” dashboard, ensuring immediate user familiarity.
- **Navigation:** Initiated by clicking a user's avatar or name from the sidebar, global search, or feed. The internal tabs dynamically swap the lower content view without leaving the profile.